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We Had Chemistry

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We had Chemistry

By Tracy Nuss

For Jayla C.

Synopsis: *A high school girl finds herself in the school counselor's office to recount the day's events. Normally, she's the peak of near perfection but today she found herself distracted by… a boy. She proceeds to tell the story of one comedic disaster after another that happened in Chemistry class that day.*

Ms. Smith, as a school counselor, have you ever seen a perfectly, intelligent girl suddenly go dumb because of a boy? Take any girl and ask her the capital of Nicaragua and she'll tell you the correct answer in the blink of an eye. Ask her to add two plus two in front of a boy and she'll tell you five... It's the most insane thing ever. I can't stand it when I watch my friends completely forget themselves anytime a 6-foot bag of muscles with brown hair and blue eyes walks up. Long ago, I made myself a promise I would never be that girl. To this day, you know that I've carried a 4.0 grade point average. I scored a 35 on the ACT. As a junior, I've already been accepted into four different universities and have been offered several substantial scholarships. So, Ms. Smith, you have to believe me when I say, I have no idea what happened during 5th hour...

Let me set the scene for you. *(She begins to act out the scene in the office)* We had a lab in Chemistry. Something simple. It was a standard single replacement reaction where we were supposed to combine magnesium and hydrochloric acid which would produce a gas. Then we had to light a small wooden stick on fire and introduce it to the gas to get it to pop which would confirm it's hydrogen gas. Like I said, easy. The problems all started when Casey, my bff, decided to be sick today. It left me without a partner and Mr. Daniels decided that it would be best that, despite my protests, I should have a new partner instead of working on my own. Mr. Daniels decided to put me with Steven of all people... I mean, he's alright but he's no Casey. She and I had the two highest grades in the class. I trusted her... Why was I supposed to trust my lab score with this six-foot-tall bag of muscle, with brown hair, and blue eyes, that I've had a crush on since the 4th grade?... *(she immediately catchers her slip)* I've never said that out loud before... See Ms. Smith, something's wrong with me.

Anyway, we divided up the work. I sent him to get the lab supplies while I prepared the burner. I turned on the gas and started adjusting the airflow when I found myself watching Steven walk away. I want to say it's because I didn't trust him to grab the right materials and the right amounts, and, honestly, that was mostly the reason. But Ms. Smith, I found myself looking at... his b.... his buh... Ms. Smith, I've taken anatomy. I know the proper terminology for 98% of the parts of the human body. I was the only one in my class who could list off EVERY part of the reproductive system without turning red or giggling... Right now, I can't even say the general term for the space between Steven's lower back and his hamstrings. During this time, I must have absent-mindedly adjusted the airflow a little much. As I lit the burner, there was this huge fireball! It ignited part of the counter, the ceiling tiles, and worst of all, my trigonometry homework! I spent three hours working on it the night before and I couldn't have it, literally, going up in flames! I quickly grabbed a fire extinguisher and put it out. In a few short bursts, I had most of it put out and then it got worse.

As I was just about to finish up, I was startled by a tap on my shoulder. I jerked around and at the same time, I squeezed the extinguisher one more time. I fired it directly at Steven who was trying to get my attention... while he was still holding concentrated hydrochloric acid... which he then proceeded to dump all over himself. I heard it start to sizzle... According to Mr. Daniels, in 23 years of teaching, he has never had to use the safety shower... until today. Ms. Smith, do you know the protocol for a chemical spill? You have to remove any affected clothing! Mr. Daniels comes over and gets Steven to take off his shirt and positions him under the shower. Steven is now shirtless… under a shower in the classroom... I couldn't look away... Ms. Smith, it was bad and so embarrassing. I wish I could say it ended there...

I felt compelled to tell Steven that I was sorry. I walked over to him forgetting that the floor was wet from the shower... I slipped... into him. He caught me and we both fell to the ground. When I opened my eyes, I was on top of him. I waited what seemed like hours for Steven to open his eyes. He didn't. I must have knocked him out! Ms. Smith, I'm trained in CPR. I've worked as a lifeguard. My instincts kicked in. I was going to have to start rescue breaths! I brought my mouth in close to give the breath of life... or a kiss. I don't really know any more at this point. I was about a centimeter away from contact when he opened his eyes... It turns out the time that passed was only about 5 seconds... He was fine. I got up and sprinted out of the room and now two hours later, I'm here.

So, needless to say, Ms. Smith, I'm here to formally request you start the paperwork so I can transfer to a new school. First of all, I cannot show my face around here ever again and definitely cannot show my face to Steven ever again. Second of all, I cannot have these types of distractions with the kinds of goals I have in mind. Never in my right mind did I ever think I would behave like this. I think there's an all-girls school on the other side of the city. Anyway, thanks for listening Ms. Smith. I have a detention I need to go serve. Mr. Daniels said it should only take about an hour to clean up the lab and then I can go home... Oh, Ms. Smith? If you happen to see Steven, can you tell him I'm sorry, and if he's not doing anything in about 8-10 years I'll look him up?